

a bad, irresponsible person, but I do know better.

4. Your money is only yours

You earned it so it's yours to spend. However you like. Whenever you like. Wherever you like. End of story. You can publish your budget on the Internet, but you don't have to. If others are going to be critical, keep them out. You're also the one trying to be responsible with your money here, which means that it's fine to ask for help if you want it. But don't ask from someone who isn't going to approve your categories, your amounts, or anything else about your budget. You make it, you keep it.

5. Work with a group

If you're trying to learn to budget, find some friends who are in the same boat, or who have been budgeting for a while. Agree to meet and talk about how your budget is going, whether you're keeping it up, etc. If you're worried that they might not approve of your choices or understand your categories, agree beforehand that they can help you keep to what you budget, but can't set your categories or criticize the decisions you've made unless you ask them for that kind of advice.

6. Give it at least six months before you give up

If you haven't done it before, budgeting is a new habit. It takes a while to feel natural, not kludgy, and not binding. Give it at least six months before you decide to throw in the towel. Stick with your decision to record your spending and you may just find that it fits you after all. It's like switching to shoes when you've worn sandals for years—they feel tight, but they're really the right size.

While budgeting is difficult, it's not impossible, and it does get better with time. Stick with it. Have courage. Face down the evil checkbook. Eventually, you can be triumphant.

— Sarah Winfrey



How to Choose a Financial Planner

I don't care who you are. (Well, actually I do, otherwise I wouldn't be writing this.) What I mean is, I